

LIFE AFTER ALICE

Episode 1: "Contingency"

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Cold open. Approx. five minutes. Draft 03: roughening pass.
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FADE IN:

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - WAITING ROOM - MORNING

A plastic fern. A water cooler that gurgles every forty seconds. A laminated sign: PLEASE SWITCH PHONES TO SILENT.

ALICE, 40s, headscarf, cardigan buttoned one hole out, peels a satsuma in a single unbroken strip. She lays the peel on her knee.

DANIEL, 40s, beside her. A clipboard. His pen hovers over "Reason for attending" and stays there.

ALICE
Put logistics.

DANIEL
I'm not putting logistics.

ALICE
Put anything, she won't read it.

DANIEL
She'll read it.

She takes the clipboard off him, writes one word, hands it back with a segment of satsuma.

He eats the satsuma. Reads the form: "HIM."

DANIEL (CONT'D)
That's not even -- that's not a reason.

A door opens. RUTH, 60s, reading glasses on a chain, leans out.

RUTH
Alice? And... Daniel? Sorry. Did you find us alright? The car park's a nightmare.

DANIEL
Yeah.

ALICE
No.

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - RUTH'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Two armchairs. A sofa. A box of tissues on a low table.
Alice takes an armchair. Daniel takes the far end of the
sofa. The clock is loud.

Ruth sits. Finds her pen. Doesn't find her pen. Finds it.

RUTH
So I usually like to start by just
--

Alice already has a black notebook out of her bag. Coloured
tabs. On the cover, in silver marker: LIFE AFTER ALICE.

ALICE
Sorry, I've -- I did an agenda. Is
that -- I did an agenda. Item one's
the boiler. The service plan renews
in March and he'll let it lapse, he
lets everything --

DANIEL
Al.

ALICE
-- the car tax, he let the car tax
--

DANIEL
That was once. She's not a
solicitor.

ALICE
I know she's not a -- I know what
she is, Dan. I'm not -- I'm dying,
I'm not thick.

Nobody moves. Daniel looks at the tissues. Ruth writes
something down. Or pretends to.

RUTH
And Daniel, is that -- are you
alright with starting there?

DANIEL
Yeah. No, I mean. Yeah. It's fine.

RUTH
Was there anything you wanted to --

DANIEL
Um.

He thinks about it.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
Not really. Not... being here, I
suppose. That'd be my item one.

ALICE
Item one's taken.

She laughs. Nobody else does. She keeps laughing a second too long, then stops.

His eyes go to the notebook on her knee.

FLASH TO:

INT. THEIR KITCHEN - NIGHT (THREE WEEKS EARLIER)

Two a.m. Rain on the glass. One lamp on.

Alice at the table in a dressing gown, writing in the notebook. A row of highlighters in front of her, lids off.

Daniel in the doorway, squinting.

DANIEL
What time is it?

ALICE
Did I wake you?

DANIEL
The light did. What time --

ALICE
Two. Ish.

He comes to the table. Reads the cover. Reads it again.

DANIEL
What's that?

ALICE
It's a notebook.

DANIEL
Al.

ALICE
It's for the -- it's just lists,
it's boring, go back to bed.

He picks up a highlighter. Puts the lid on. Picks up the next one. Lid on. All of them, one by one, while she watches him.

ALICE (CONT'D)
I was using those.

He goes. She waits until she hears the stairs.

Then she takes the lids off again. One by one.

BACK TO:

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - RUTH'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Ruth holds out a hand for the notebook. Alice hesitates, then gives it up. Ruth turns pages: a diagram of the fuse box. THINGS HE WILL GET WRONG. A page with only COLANDER - BOTTOM LEFT, underlined three times.

RUTH
Gosh. This is...

ALICE
I ran projects for eleven years.
Nothing I ran ever came in late.

DANIEL
Well this one's coming in early, so
--

It's out. He hears it.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
That came out -- I didn't --

ALICE
(overlapping)
Page fourteen.

RUTH
Sorry, which --

ALICE
Fourteen. The blue tab.

Ruth finds it.

RUTH
(reading)
"Daniel to join a cycling club by
June."

DANIEL
I've got a bike.

ALICE
You've got a bike in the shed with
two flat tyres.

DANIEL
One. One flat tyre.

ALICE
You need a date on things or you
don't --

DANIEL
I'll do what I want. After.

ALICE
After what?

Nothing.

ALICE (CONT'D)
No, go on. After what?

He gets up. Goes to the window. Stands with his back to the
room.

FLASH TO:

INT. HOSPITAL CORRIDOR - DAY (EIGHT MONTHS EARLIER)

Strip lights. A vending machine hums.

Alice on a plastic chair, a leaflet folded very small in her
fist. Daniel pacing, thumb going on his phone.

DANIEL
There's a place in Heidelberg. Hang
on. Heidelberg or -- there's a
trial on, anyway, and if we go
private it's --

ALICE
Can you get me some crisps.

DANIEL
What?

ALICE
Crisps.

He stops. Stares at her. She holds out a pound coin.

He feeds the machine. The spiral turns. The packet tips forward. Hangs there.

He hits the glass. Flat palm. Then his fist. Again. Again --

The packet drops. He stays there, forehead on the glass, knuckles split.

He brings her the crisps. Sits. Looks at the packet.

DANIEL
They're prawn cocktail.

ALICE
I hate prawn cocktail.

She opens them anyway. Eats one. Then she starts laughing. He doesn't, at first. Then he does, the awful kind, and puts his head in her lap.

BACK TO:

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - RUTH'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Daniel at the window. He rubs his thumb across two of his knuckles. A faded white scar.

RUTH
Daniel, can I try something? It's a Tuesday. A year from now. About seven o'clock. Where are you?

DANIEL
What?

RUTH
A Tuesday, a year --

DANIEL
No, I heard. I don't know.

RUTH
Have a guess.

A long time.

DANIEL
The kitchen. Probably. I don't --

RUTH
Doing what?

DANIEL
Nothing. Standing in it.

RUTH
Is the light on?

He doesn't answer. Alice closes the notebook.

ALICE
The colander's the -- it's bottom
left. Behind the thing. The slow
cooker. You've been doing pasta
with a lid for eleven years, it
goes everywhere, it goes all over
the --

Her voice goes. Mid-word. She presses the notebook against
her mouth.

Daniel turns. Crosses the room. Not fast. Kneels on the
carpet in front of her chair and puts his arms round her
waist, his head against her.

Her hand finds the back of his neck. Holds on. Ruth looks at
the tissues and doesn't move them.

DANIEL
(into her cardigan)
I'll get a --

ALICE
You've got one.

DANIEL
I'll get another one.

ALICE
What for?

DANIEL
I don't know.

She laughs into his hair. It goes wrong halfway through.

Ruth glances at the clock. Waits. Glances again.

RUTH
Sorry, we're -- we're nearly at
time. Um. For next week. One thing
each, in the back of the book.
Daniel, something you want. For
after. And Alice, something for --
for now.

Alice opens the notebook at the back and holds the pen out to him. He looks at it a long time. Takes it. Writes. Crosses something out. Writes again: "Learn the lasagne."

She reads it.

ALICE
It's not even hard. You just layer
it.

Underneath, she writes: "FRIDAY. KITCHEN. LAMP ON. DANCE."
Shows him.

DANIEL
I can't dance.

ALICE
I know.

Alice stands, coat half on, an arm stuck in the lining.

ALICE (CONT'D)
Same time next week? Is that -- do
we book at the desk?

RUTH
At the desk, yes. Same time.

Alice goes. Daniel follows. Stops in the doorway.

DANIEL
And when it's --

He can't.

RUTH
We'll -- yes. We'll keep the slot.
We'll talk about it.

He nods. Goes.

Ruth alone. On the cushion of Alice's chair: a long curl of satsuma peel. Ruth picks it up. Looks for a bin. There isn't one. She puts it on the windowsill.

CUT TO BLACK.

LIFE AFTER ALICE